

Ankle Swelling - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1448 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- UAT-only adult and pediatric ankle-swelling pathway screening for pulmonary embolism, thrombosis, infection, pregnancy complications and systemic oedema before in-person assessment.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the swelling lasted?
2. [YES_NO] Is one ankle more swollen than the other?
3. [YES_NO] Any shortness of breath or chest pain?
4. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the age; is there pregnancy/recent birth, clot history, cancer, surgery/immobility/travel, heart/kidney/liver disease, medicines, fever, injury, or child safeguarding concern?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Motor Vehicle Accident

Did this problem begin with a motor vehicle crash or as part of a multi-system crash injury?

A motor vehicle crash or multi-system crash injury belongs in the Motor Vehicle Accident pathway.

1. Disposition level 100

Is one ankle much more swollen than the other, along with shortness of breath or chest pain?

One-sided ankle/leg swelling with breathing or chest symptoms is a recognized blood clot red flag, consistent with the Leg Pain/Wells DVT concept already used in this system.

1. Disposition level 70

Is the swelling hot and red, is the person unwell or feverish, or is the ankle swelling worse with breathlessness on exertion or lying down?

Consistent with NHS.UK joint pain and shortness-of-breath guidance - swollen ankles alongside breathlessness can indicate a heart or circulation problem needing prompt review.

1. Disposition level 70

With no emergency feature, is ankle swelling persistent, unexplained, unilateral, painful/hot, associated with breathlessness, pregnancy/postpartum status, systemic disease or childhood?

Telephone assessment cannot safely determine benign oedema or exclude vascular, cardiac, renal, hepatic, pregnancy-related or inflammatory causes.

Advice

Qatar emergency swelling response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for breathlessness, chest pain/tightness, coughing blood, faintness/confusion/clamminess or severe rapid swelling. Do not allow self-driving or massage the swollen limb. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening breathing difficulty; chest pain develops.

Same-day ankle-swelling assessment

- Arrange same-day in-person assessment for unilateral, sudden, painful, red/hot or unexplained swelling, fever, diabetes, pregnancy/postpartum status, or kidney/heart/liver disease. Exact Qatar vascular, maternity and medical destinations are local approval required.
- Call Back If: breathlessness; swelling spreads; pain or fever.

Unexplained swelling needs clinical review

- Arrange in-person review before assuming benign oedema or changing salt, fluid, diuretic or other medicine. Elevate gently if comfortable; do not massage unilateral swelling.
- Call Back If: one ankle becomes more swollen; breathlessness develops.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 for breathlessness, chest pain/tightness, coughing blood, faintness/confusion/clamminess or severe rapid swelling. Do not allow self-driving or massage the swollen limb. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Joint pain", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/joint-pain/> (page last reviewed 26 February 2026)
- NHS.UK, "Shortness of breath" (swollen-ankle criterion, already cited for Breathing Difficulty, batch18), <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/shortness-of-breath/>

Provenance

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